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Swiss Red Cross



COMMUNITY HEALTH MODULE

Community
volunteering



ABOUT THIS MODULE

This module introduces the International Red Cross Red Crescent Movement, its principles and how Red Cross Red Crescent volunteers put these principles into action. It outlines how the Movement began, how it functions, and the many roles, responsibilities and rights volunteers have in supporting health, safety and inclusion in their communities.



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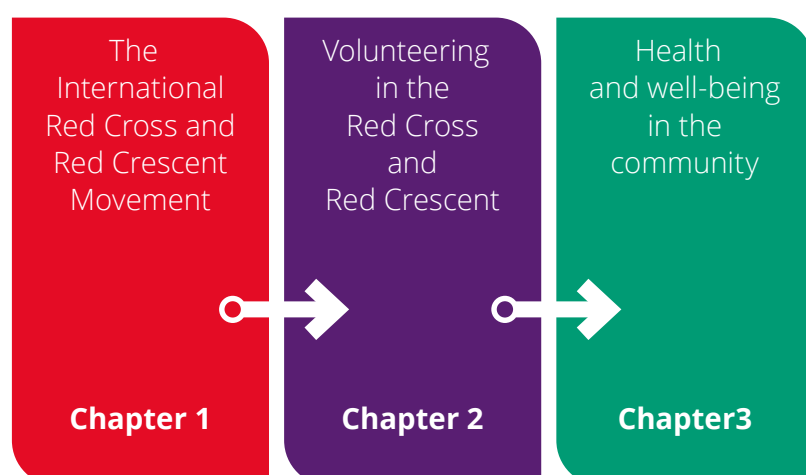
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LEARNING GUIDE FOR THIS MODULE



CHAPTER 1



The International Red Cross and Red Crescent Movement

1.1 HOW IT BEGAN

The Red Cross Red Crescent Movement was born from one person's compassion in the face of suffering. In 1859, during the Second War of Italian Independence, Henry Dunant, a young Swiss man, came across thousands of wounded soldiers left without care on the battlefield after the Battle of Solferino in Italy. Shocked, he gathered local villagers to help, caring for everyone, no matter which side they fought on. This simple act of humanity inspired what became the International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC) and the Geneva Conventions – the foundations of today's Red Cross Red Crescent Movement, the largest humanitarian network in the world.

1.2 THE THREE PARTS OF THE MOVEMENT

The International Red Cross and Red Crescent Movement has three parts working together as one global network.

1. **International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC)** – acts mainly in armed conflict settings, protecting affected people and promoting international humanitarian law. It visits prisoners, helps trace missing people, reunites families, clears unexploded weapons and reminds all sides of their obligations under the Geneva Conventions.



ICRC

2. **International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies (IFRC)** is a membership organization coordinating all National Societies worldwide. It supports them to strengthen their capacities and to serve their communities before, during and after emergencies. At the same time, the IFRC coordinates help between countries, especially in emergencies, health crises and recovery.



3. **National Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies** – there is a National Society in almost every country in the world, recognized by their governments as auxiliaries to public authorities in the humanitarian field, and staffed largely by volunteers. They act locally to support communities through health, first aid and disaster preparedness and recovery.

Together they form a single humanitarian network guided by shared principles and a joint mission, to bring humanity to whomever and wherever it is needed most.

The International Red Cross and Red Crescent Movement

1.3 THE SEVEN FUNDAMENTAL PRINCIPLES

The Movement's work is guided by **Seven Fundamental Principles** that protect its independence and inspire trust everywhere in the world.

1 Humanity – prevent and ease suffering wherever it is found; protect life, health and human dignity.



2 Impartiality – help based on need alone, without discrimination of nationality, race, gender, belief or opinion.



3 Neutrality – never take sides in conflict or engage in political, religious or ideological disputes. Neutrality allows volunteers to reach everyone in need.



4 Independence – while supporting public authorities, National Societies must always act freely, according to humanitarian principles, not political influence.



5 Volunteer service – our work is driven by compassion, not reward or gain. Volunteers act freely to serve their communities.



6 Unity – there can be only one Red Cross or Red Crescent Society in any country. It must be open to all and work throughout its territory.



7 Universality – all Societies have equal status and share equal responsibilities and duties to support one another worldwide.



These principles allow every volunteer to act safely, fairly and confidently, even in challenging situations.

The International Red Cross and Red Crescent Movement

1.4 THE EMBLEMS

The red cross, red crescent and red crystal are the Movement's official emblems, recognized by international law. National Societies select one of these.



Red cross



Red crescent



Red crystal

The emblems have two distinct purposes:

- **Protective use – in times of conflict**
 - To protect medical and humanitarian workers, vehicles and buildings
 - Protects from attack under international humanitarian law
 - Reserved for authorized medical and humanitarian personnel
- **Indicative use – in times of peace**
 - Identifies people, property and activities belonging to the Movement
 - Seen on volunteer uniforms, ID vehicles, buildings, materials, etc.
 - Shown with the name of the National Society (e.g. Kenya Red Cross, Red Crescent Society of Kyrgyzstan, etc.)

Wearing the emblems represents care, humanity and neutrality. Misuse of them – for commercial, political or decorative purposes etc. can endanger lives, undermine trust and weaken the legal protections the emblems provide.

The International Red Cross and Red Crescent Movement

1.5 HOW THE MOVEMENT WORKS

The Red Cross and Red Crescent Movement is global – but its strength comes from local action, starting from volunteers and local Red Cross Red Crescent branches.

Volunteers and branches

- Volunteers are at the heart of the Movement.
- Most belong to a local branch, made up of staff, members and volunteers working together to meet community needs.
- Branches organize activities such as first aid, community health, disaster response and restoring family links. They often partner with local health centres, schools and community groups to strengthen local well-being and resilience.
- Knowing your local branch and the branches nearby helps you connect, share information and work together when emergencies happen

National Societies

- National Societies are recognized by their country's government as voluntary organizations supporting public authorities in their auxiliary role.
- Each National Society coordinates all its branches, provides training and guidance, and ensures that volunteers can act safely and effectively.
- Because volunteers come from their own communities, they are often the first to respond and remain active in recovery long after emergencies end.

The IFRC Secretariat

- Based in Geneva with regional and country offices, the IFRC Secretariat supports National Societies around the world, helping them share experience and strengthen capacity, while also coordinating international assistance when large scale disasters or crises occur.
- Volunteers form branches, branches build National Societies, and together they create a global network of humanitarian action.



CHAPTER 2



Volunteering in the Red Cross and Red Crescent

2.1 DEFINITION OF VOLUNTEERING IN THE MOVEMENT

A Red Cross Red Crescent volunteer is a person who carries out volunteering activities or services, out of their free will and not by a desire for material or financial gain, on behalf of the IFRC network, occasionally, or regularly, and always working in accordance with the Fundamental Principles of the International Red Cross Red Crescent Movement. See the full volunteering policy [here](#).

2.2 WHO VOLUNTEERS ARE

Volunteers are the heart and hands of the movement. They are people of the community – students, workers, parents, retirees – who choose to make a difference in their own communities. The Movement has around 16 million volunteers worldwide.

A volunteer might:

- Respond to emergencies and first aid needs
- Visit isolated or elderly people
- Share health information or promote safety
- Organize local events, activities and awareness campaigns

Most volunteers give a few hours each week, but each volunteer is different. The activities they carry out vary depending on context, experience and interests. What all volunteers share is a humanitarian motivation and a sense of solidarity with their community and its vulnerable people.

Volunteering in the Red Cross and Red Crescent

2.3 WHY VOLUNTEERING MATTERS

Volunteers make the Movement trusted and effective because they:

- Understand their communities – they share language, culture and experience. They know the vulnerabilities and strengths of the community.
- Build relationships – people trust and accept help more easily from someone they know or someone from the community.
- Act quickly – when emergencies happen, volunteers are already there and ready to help.
- Create long-term change – they strengthen health, safety and inclusion of the community every day, building lasting resilience.

2.4 VOLUNTEER RESPONSIBILITIES AND PROTECTION

Volunteering is a partnership built on trust, safety and shared purpose.

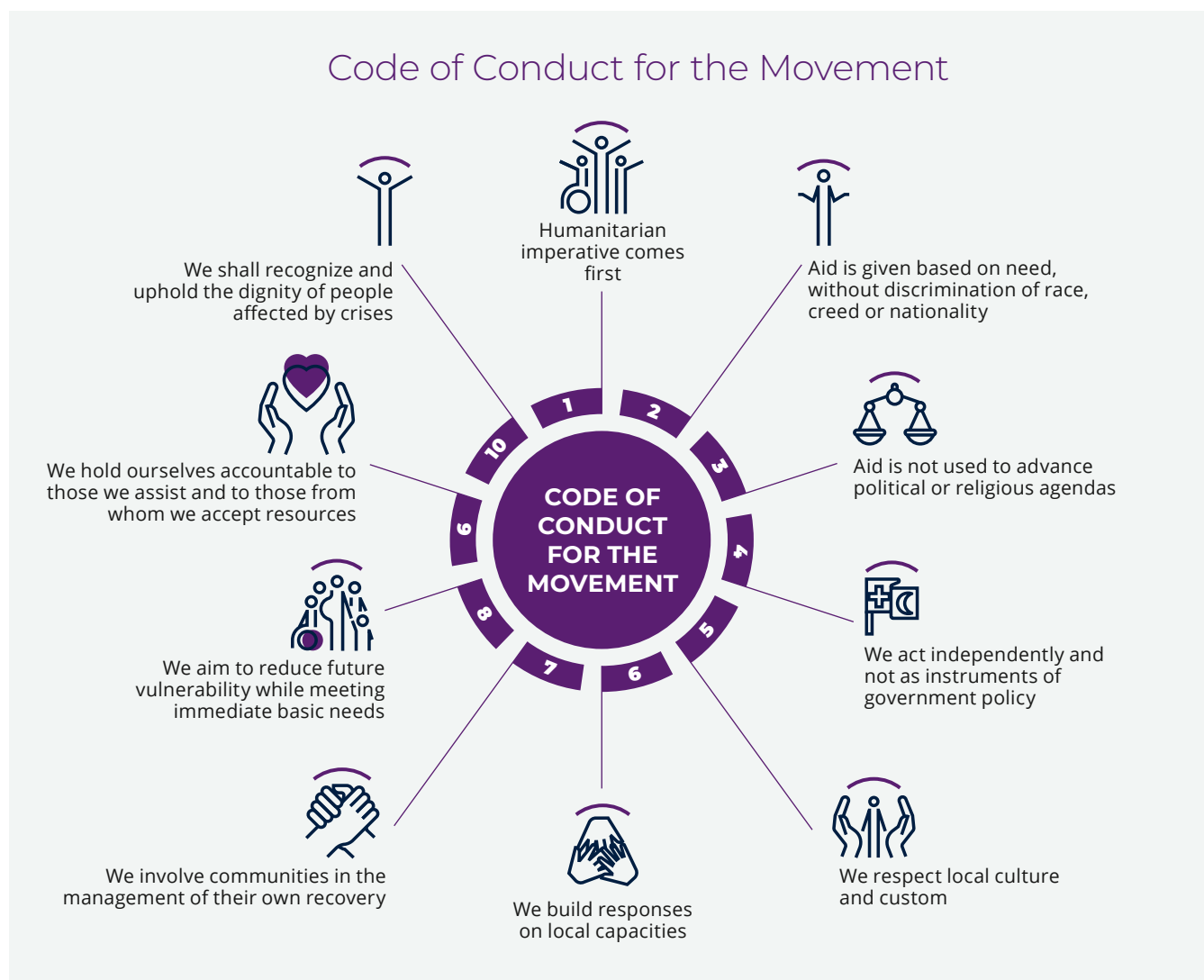
Responsibilities:

- Act according to the Fundamental Principles and emblem and adhere to the Code of Conduct of the Movement.
- Treat all people with respect, without discrimination.
- Protect privacy and dignity of those you serve in all activities.
- Work safely and follow training and guidance.
- Use the emblem responsibly and represent the Movement positively.
- Be available in disasters or emergencies, as agreed with the National Society and according to your skills and abilities.
- Get rest and look after yourself too.

Protection and rights include:

- The right to be treated fairly, safely and with respect.
- Access to appropriate training, equipment and supervision for your role.
- Accident insurance and safety cover when volunteering.
- Reimbursement of agreed expenses.
- The right to accept or refuse roles consistent with the Code of Conduct and voluntary service.
- The right to file complaints anonymously, see [here](#).
- Protection from and have the duty to prevent and respond to sexual exploitation and abuse, see [here](#).
- Access to psychosocial support.

Volunteering in the Red Cross and Red Crescent



2.5 THE IMPACT OF VOLUNTEERING

Volunteering changes lives – for communities and for the volunteers themselves. For communities, it builds preparedness, safety and social connection. For volunteers, it develops confidence, skills, friendship and purpose.

Across the world, millions of Red Cross and Red Crescent volunteers save lives, support recovery and spread hope every day. Each act of service adds to something greater, a global movement of humanity in action.

CHAPTER 3



Health and well-being in the community

3.1 HEALTH AND WELL-BEING

The World Health Organization defines health as: A state of complete physical, mental and social well-being and not merely the absence of disease or infirmity¹.

This includes:

- Access to food, water, shelter and care (physical health).
- Feeling safe, hopeful and able to cope with stress (mental health).
- Feeling valued, included and connected to others (social well-being).

The Movement recognizes that these are interconnected and depend on several basic conditions such as shelter, safe water and sanitation, food and nutrition, access to healthcare, livelihood, security, social belonging, and the ability to cope and function in daily life.

When one of these conditions is weakened, such as loss of income, unsafe housing or isolation, the others are affected too. Volunteers help strengthen all these by working with communities, identifying needs early, and supporting people before problems grow.

By promoting health, protecting well-being, and reinforcing social connections, volunteers help build safer and more resilient communities

¹ WHO constitution: [Constitution of the World Health Organization](#)

Health and well-being in the community

3.2 THE VOLUNTEER'S ROLE IN COMMUNITY HEALTH

Volunteers are essential in improving and protecting community health and well-being. They help communities to:

- Stay healthy and prevent illness:
 - Support people to adopt healthy behaviours related to hygiene, nutrition, disease prevention, etc.
 - Support health, vaccination and blood donation campaigns
 - Teach and deliver first aid so people can respond to everyday injuries
 - Help distribute health materials such as mosquito nets or hygiene kits
- **Protect mental health and build resilience:**
 - Offer psychological first aid and listen with empathy after distressing events
 - Create safe spaces for children, youth and older people to connect and share
 - Promote activities that strengthen hope, belonging and emotional recovery after crises
- **Support social well-being:**
 - Encourage inclusion, making sure no one is left out because of age, gender, disability or background
 - Help reconnect separated families and support migrants or displaced people
 - Organize community events and awareness campaigns that build unity and pride.
- **Prepare for and recover from emergencies:**
 - Raise awareness about risks such as floods, fires or disease outbreaks
 - Support community emergency plans and practice drills
 - Check on vulnerable neighbours, link people with services, help restore safe routines and support recovery.

Health and well-being in the community

3.3 SUPPORTING PEOPLE IN VULNERABLE SITUATIONS

Health and well-being depend not only on access to care but also on inclusion, dignity and safety. Some people in the community face greater risks to their health and lives because they have fewer resources or face barriers that make it harder to cope, recover or participate.

Vulnerability means having a reduced ability to prevent, cope with or recover from challenges such as poverty, discrimination, disasters or violence. It is not a permanent condition; it changes with circumstances and environment.

People may be in vulnerable situations when they are:

- Isolated or excluded from community life
- Unable to access services or information
- Facing discrimination or harmful social norms
- Lacking resources or support to meet basic needs

Examples include:

- Young children and older people
- Pregnant and nursing women
- Persons with disabilities
- Migrants or displaced people
- Female- or child-headed households without social support
- Those facing social or economic exclusion

Those factors often overlap and increase risk. Recognizing them helps volunteers reach those who might otherwise be left behind. Volunteers play a vital role in identifying and supporting people in vulnerable situations. This means:

- Listening to people's own priorities and concerns
- Ensuring that all activities are inclusive and accessible
- Linking people to services such as health, protection or social support
- Treating everyone with dignity and respect

When volunteers act inclusively, they help reduce inequality, strengthen trust and improve the overall health and resilience of the community.

Health and well-being in the community

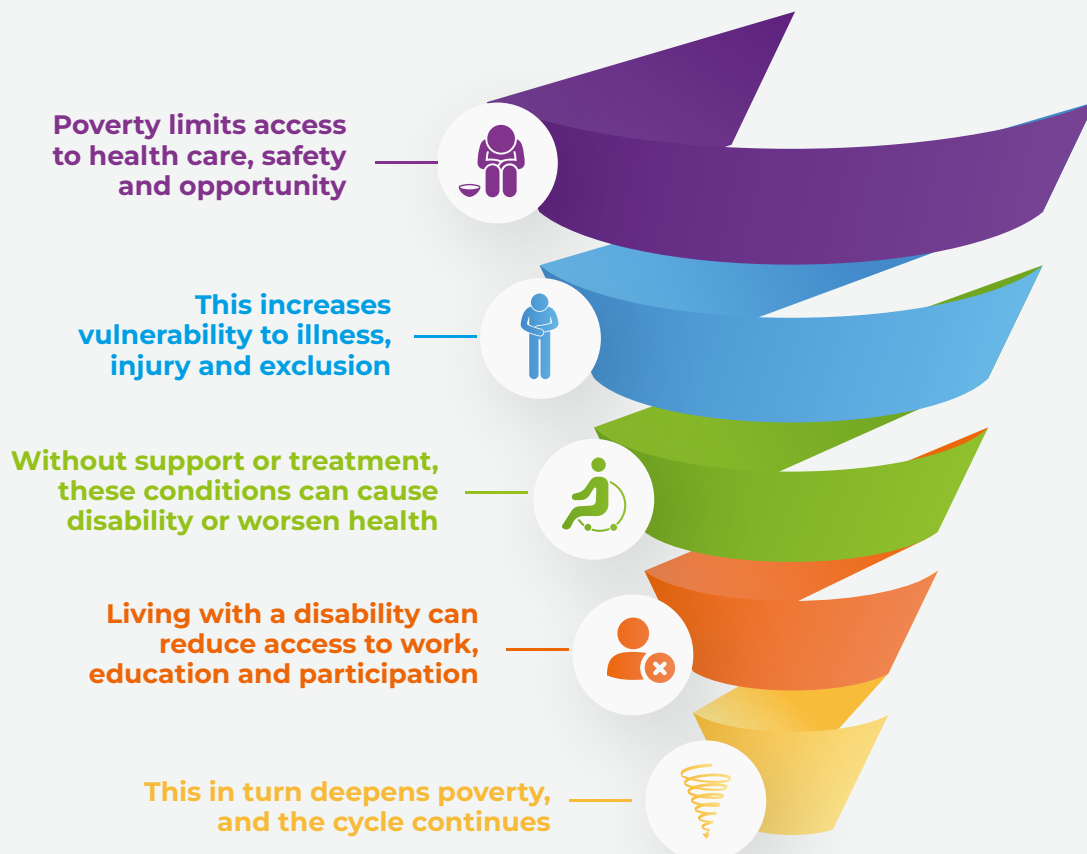
3.5 THE CYCLE OF POVERTY AND VULNERABILITY

People that live in poverty, people with disabilities or other vulnerabilities face additional barriers that increase their vulnerability further, including:

- Limited access to education, health care or employment
- Unsafe or inaccessible physical environments
- Negative social attitudes or stigma
- Reduced opportunity to participate in decisions that affect them

These barriers make it harder to live safely, stay healthy or be included in community life. Vulnerability – such as poverty or poor access to health care – can also increase the likelihood of disability, creating a negative cycle that can be difficult to break.

The cycle of poverty, vulnerability and disability



Health and well-being in the community

Red Cross and Red Crescent volunteers help interrupt this cycle by improving access, inclusion and dignity – ensuring that people with disabilities can participate fully and safely in their community.

Volunteers who work to include and stand beside those most at risk or left behind live the spirit of the Red Cross and Red Crescent Movement – acting from compassion and a humanitarian imperative, bringing hope and strength where it is needed most.

For more information on volunteering with the Movement visit the IFRC volunteer website: [Volunteer with us | IFRC](#). To know more about the IFRC volunteering vision, scope, definitions and responsibilities, visit the IFRC volunteering policy: [Volunteering policy | IFRC](#).

Community health series



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The **International Federation of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies (IFRC)** is the world's largest humanitarian network, with **191 National Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies** and around **16 million volunteers**. Our volunteers are present in communities before, during and after a crisis or disaster. We work in the most hard to reach and complex settings in the world, saving lives and promoting human dignity. We support communities to become stronger and more resilient places where people can live safe and healthy lives, and have opportunities to thrive.